

KF17 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Let’s briefly look at our definition of karis: karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity. What does that mean? The word *karis* is used in Greek to say *thank you*. When a person gives you a gift, you must decide whether you want to return a gift to show your gratitude. If you do not offer a gift in return—not even the simple gift of saying thank you—you are letting others know that you are not interested in their gift nor in the benefits of a relationship with them. When Jesus came into our lives, He came as a karis gift from God. Are you returning any gifts to God as evidence of your gratitude and your desire for more relationship?

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

A productive goal is to spend twenty to thirty minutes, twice a day, in prayer and meditation. The benefits of meditation practice are “dose dependent”. That means you will benefit in proportion to the amount of effort you invest. However, any effort to meditate and practice mindfulness is success.

Have you had a chance or felt a need to practice the **Mercy Meditation** this week?¹ Whenever you rebel against your shoulds and taboos, the Idol Self will have no mercy on you and will punish you with self-hate. When that happens, you will need to show mercy to yourself. Self-promotion or increased self-care will throw self-effacing types into self-hate. For a mastery type, letting something slide or extending mercy invites self-hate and is often followed by aggression or self-sabotage. Resigned people might feel vaguely uncomfortable after a moment of self-revelation or strong emotion. They might then be irritable or seek numbness again. The **Mercy Meditation** helps us show mercy to ourselves despite our shoulds and the judgments we make about our behaviors and feelings. When our judgmental attitude has calmed down, we can see our value and appreciate the efforts we are making today toward wholeness; and once we know our own value, we can extend value to others as a gift.

The Mercy Meditation

Sit quietly for a few moments. Notice your breath and settle into your environment. *(Pause)* As you breathe, sense the air moving in and out. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Scan your body for tension. On the exhale, allow your body to soften. *(Pause)* Give any tense areas permission to relax, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Draw your mind away from the events of the day, from the past or the future, and from others. Focus on what is happening inside your skin, right now. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

And now, reflect for thirty seconds on each of the following three questions. Feel free to jot down your thoughts as they knock on the door of your mind. Observe your feelings and any physical sensations.

1. In what areas am I most critical of myself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. If you haven't done so already, take thirty seconds to jot down what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. For what do I need to forgive myself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause, and if you wish, jot down your thoughts. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. How do I treat myself when I make a mistake? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause, and write for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now experiment with bringing compassion to yourself in some way. For example, call to mind someone who loves you just as you are. This might be someone divine, like God or Jesus, or perhaps someone mortal and human. You might call to mind one of God's other creatures. *(Pause)* Imagine seeing yourself through their eyes. You might give yourself an appreciative hug. *(Pause)* However you choose to bring compassion to yourself, just observe and rest for one minute. Practice letting go of judgment and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause. Sometime this week, try reflecting for one minute on each of those questions and then practice bringing compassion to yourself.

Our hymn for this confession is *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross*.

See, from His head, His hands, His feet,
Sorrow and love flow mingled down.
Did ever such love and sorrow meet,
Or thorns compose so rich a crown?²

Take a deep breath.

Next week we will practice the **Mercy Meditation** and apply it to others.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

During the past three lessons, we have been looking at the **Shoulds Worksheet**. We are learning to untangle the stories that we fabricate about our disappointments, fears, and judgments. Perhaps we can

see how we punish ourselves for not being perfect. We also looked at what we expect from others and what we imagine others expect from us. These are externalized shoulds. When we are unable to actualize our idealized glory, we try to make others do it for us. If I do not handle money well, I may think that my husband should. If I cannot live up to my standards of glory, I might try to make my own child live up to those standards. In this way, I can avoid making a real effort toward my own development. I can also avoid my own self-hate and blame others for my frustrations. The sad thing is that when others do not achieve our standards, we punish them with the same fierce aggression that we use against ourselves.

Let's turn our attention now to another component of the Idol's legal system: the claim. According to Dr. Horney, a claim is applied in two ways.³ First, we make the claim that we are entitled to privileges and are exempt from common limitations, suffering, and struggles. We believe that we should receive special care, consideration, and deference. We think that we have a right to get away with our misoriented choices. The more misoriented we are, the stronger our opinions will be about what is right and fair, and the more claims we will impose on others and on life. Perhaps the most prevalent claim of this type is that we do not need to struggle and endure to become mature and complete, lacking in nothing; for us, growth and healing should happen quickly and effortlessly.⁴ We might claim that we can be well after attending a few KF meetings because we are just smarter than other people.

In our pride, we believe that we are so special that we should be able to ignore common rules of engagement. For example, we might claim that we are exempt from maintaining the speed limit or from showing up on time. Intense feelings then result from a traffic ticket or from a missed flight. We might feel extreme frustration when others do things differently or do not go out of their way to make us feel comfortable. We might even claim the right to live in a God-fearing country! Perhaps we are disrespectful to others but require that others treat us with respect. One of our most damaging claims, however, is the story that, even though we call ourselves Christians, we are exempt from following Jesus, doing what He says, and living as He lived in this world. We excuse ourselves from going through what He went through; we imagine that we are above our Master.⁵ These are just a few examples of the entitlements and exemptions that we claim to be our right.

Second, we make a claim when we believe something about ourselves that is not supported by evidence. Without that evidence, we will need to lie to ourselves about our assets, such as our intelligence, our abilities, or our spiritual maturity. These lies help us weave the fabric of our virtue stories, those pride-supporting narratives about who we are and why we do what we do. When I was a younger Christian, I attributed to myself the qualities of peace and love because my Idol Self required me to appear peaceful and loving, both to myself and to others. However, the evidence of my life revealed a person who was easily frustrated, extremely anxious, and constantly compelled to control others. I did not want to look at the evidence of my actual life because I had no means of dealing with the self-hate that would follow the exposure of my illusions. I could not rejoice in the truth. Truth was terrifying to me, and to psychically survive, I had to claim to have certain attributes that I did not actually possess.

Underlying our claims and driving our egocentric efforts to save our pride system is the deep fear that we are not good enough. Unmet claims threaten to shatter our illusions about ourselves by revealing that we are mere creatures, creatures who have limitations and are just trying to figure it all out. When we are confused about what is real and what is illusion, we cannot express the Fruit of the Spirit in our lives, nor can we support another person in their development—we are literally too frightened to do so. If our delusions are exposed, we have very strong reactions of self-hate, and in order to protect ourselves from the horror of that self-hate and the pain of self-examination, we tell a story that blames our circumstances or makes others responsible for our distress. Our story may be that we feel hurt because we are

particularly sensitive or because others are intentionally trying to hurt us. If we are impatient, we might excuse our impatience with the story that others are stupid or too slow. If we feel angry or cheated, we might imagine that others are slighting or abusing us. The more egocentric we are, the more frustration we feel when we don't get our own way or are not treated the way we think we deserve. That frustration becomes the justification for a critical attitude or for mowing people down with a machine gun of strong feelings and shaming words.

Our beautiful imagination is one of God's great gifts. It helps us envision our true glory in Christ and tell stories that teach and inspire. But the Idol can also use that imagination. Through the power of imagination, we can become the star of our own little soap opera and write our own script. In fact, our neurotic culture encourages us to escape into fantasies about life. News media and documentaries actively try to generate within us strong feelings that will lead us into judgment. We then attach to these carefully sifted and fear-based stories and make them our business. Our energies are wasted in pursuing illusions, solving imaginary problems, or defending ourselves against a threat that may not actually exist.

Sometimes our reactions to life's events help us catch a glimpse of our claims. In KF, however, we learn to do more than just catch a glimpse. We acknowledge and identify our claims and use our tools to deal with them. The **Claim and Blame Worksheet** helps us untangle our neurotic stories so that we can see what is really going on. It helps us deal with ourselves before we deal with our situation. If we can let go of our judgments, we will have the courage and freedom to seek with an open attitude and to mindfully observe what *is*—what is real, what is actual evidence. With mindful courage, we are able to be creative and follow the Holy Spirit. You might begin this week to explore the **Claim and Blame Worksheet**. You can find it on the KF website, under **Toolbox** and **Worksheets**.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, I am now ready to work on my claims. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Prayer is courageously and consistently asking, seeking, and knocking. Here is another way to think about prayer: when we ask God for something, we are also inviting Him to reveal the pride tangled up in our request. Honest prayer gives God permission to reveal our pride so that He can safely provide for us. If He provided for us without first dealing with our pride, He would be jeopardizing our personal development and the potential of our relationship with Him. As we continue to humbly knock on doors seeking His provision, we can be confident that God is dealing with any hidden pride as He skillfully guides us.

By asking, seeking, and knocking you are making discoveries about yourself, about God, about your problems, and about your pride system. Try to rejoice in the truth of those discoveries. Trust the process as you make efforts toward your healing. You might remind yourself that the degree of pain that you experience when dealing with personal problems is most likely related to the ferocity of your pride. So, deal with your pride and make your problems less painful. You will eventually find yourself at the banquet of real provision. God has promised you that.

Tackling our problems can feel like death, especially when our pride is threatened. It's so painful! But by going through the valley of the shadow of death with God, we learn to trust Him, and we discover through experience how trustworthy He is. Without your pride, the valley will be much more manageable and productive. Helen Keller, a woman with great limitations who lost both her sight and her hearing as an infant, said this: *The best way out is always through.*⁶ (Repeat) She may have been quoting the American poet Robert Frost, who said: *The only way out is through.*⁷ The only way out of your problem is to go through it. The only way to the banquet is through the valley of the shadow of death.⁸ You can learn to rejoice in your valley because it is there that you are trained and cleansed for your provision and for your mission.

Our text for this lesson is found in the letter from James, chapter 4. My paraphrase of this passage incorporates our KF understanding of the Idol and the True Self. If you have your Bible with you, I recommend that you follow along in your translation to see how the two versions compare, or you can get the teaching notes from the website and make comparisons later. As you practice comparing traditional versions with KF paraphrases, you will learn how to interpret what you read in the Bible with your new KF understanding. Remember that translations are not right or wrong. I believe that most translators are really trying to help us understand in our own language what the Bible says, but inevitably each translator brings his or her particular perspective to the text. In KF, we just are learning another perspective.

Let's read my paraphrase of **James 4:1–10**.

¹What is the cause of warfare and fighting among you and within you? Don't these causes come out of your malicious desires that advance like an army against your True Self and God, stirring up conflict within your own physical body and with other people? ²You set your heart upon some outcome and then it doesn't happen. So, you feel murderous and envious because you do not have the power to get your own way. You fight others and are at war within yourself, but you cannot have what you want, because you do not speak your reality moderately and ask for what you want.

³When you do ask for what you want, you cannot attain it because you ask for things that support the Idol Self in order to expend your real gifts on your malicious desires.

⁴Adulterers, do you not see that cozying up with the Idol's system of values and strategies makes you an enemy of God? Therefore, whoever is willing to be on the side of the Idol takes the position of enmity toward God. ⁵Do you suppose that the Scripture does not mean it when it says that the spirit that dwells in us wastes away through cravings?

⁶Scripture offers us a great gift when it shows us that God marshals Himself like an army against those who believe that they and their desires are superior to His purposes. Scripture also encourages us that God offers gifts of relationship to those who actively choose to take a low place, ready to please Him and to learn. ⁷Rather than taking a battle stance against God, submit to His leadership and get on His side. Rather than opposing God, oppose the accuser and he will abandon his threats against you.

⁸Approach God on His terms as an ally and He will approach you as an ally. Clean up your act and become of one mind with God. Recognize your misorientation. Choose to think and behave in new ways. ⁹Allow yourself to feel wretched, grieved, and sad about your misorientation. Don't be afraid to let your laughter be turned into sorrow for a time and

your joy to heaviness.¹⁰ Choose to give up the search for glory in the presence of the real Lord of your life, and let Him do the glorifying.

Take a deep breath.

In its unrelenting search for an imagined glory, our Idol Self makes unreasonable demands. Our covetous desires support the claim that we are special and entitled and, therefore, deserve to have everything go our way. We claim to always be right because being right strokes our pride. We believe that we should always be able to do, or not do, whatever we want, without any adverse consequences. No wonder there is so much strife and discontent! We are all imposing our craving desires on others and fighting to have things go our own way. We obsess about what we don't have. We obsess about forcing our "right" judgments on life—the rabid froth of our compulsive needs and our pride system. And when our pride is threatened, our self-hate is so terrifying that we have to lie to ourselves in order to survive; we must make ourselves believe that we are other than we are—and we must force others to support that belief. We imagine that if we could make the world and others be what we want them to be, we would be able to rest for a moment. Count Leo Tolstoy, the acclaimed Russian novelist, put it this way: *In our world everybody thinks of changing humanity, and nobody thinks of changing himself.*⁹ (Repeat)

You might extend some compassion to yourself if you feel a gnawing hunger to rise above what you actually are—a common creature, designed for a purpose, living in a material world that is full of limitations. You might be able to see how your need to change others reflects your own inability to love yourself as you are today.

The antidote to claims is this: choose to stop setting yourself up as the righteous judge of all the earth, full of extraordinary knowledge and wisdom. God is ready to offer you the gifts of karis relationship if you choose to take the low place, seeking to please Him and learning how to do things His way. The **Claim and Blame Worksheet** helps you recognize your misorientation and observe what is going on around you from a more empowering perspective. It helps you see how your pride is creating more pain. Joy doesn't come from having your compulsive needs met by others or by God. Joy is the Fruit of the Spirit, produced by a True Self that is deeply connected to its Creator.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Be the source of true pleasure in my soul, O God. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider how your beliefs about a particular situation prevent or shut down an open, courageous attitude. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider how your beliefs about a situation prevent or shut down an open, courageous attitude*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push away or judge your thoughts and feelings, or to make up a virtue story. We often flush thoughts or feelings from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider how your beliefs about a situation prevent or shut down an open, courageous attitude*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you consider *how your beliefs about a situation prevent or shut down an open, courageous attitude*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what resistance or the fear of losing your Idol's life feels like in your body. You might recognize the fear of others or the fear of hurt pride. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider how your beliefs about a situation prevent or shut down an open, courageous attitude*. *(Pause)* According to your Idol's standards, do you feel compelled to judge your beliefs or the situation as good or evil? *(Pause)* Is there a story that you might explore, perhaps from your past? *(Pause)* How might your Idol's pride be hurt if you were to examine the evidence behind your story? What do you fear? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

We will continue to use the idea of welcome. You might imagine a door of opportunity opening before you. As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore an area of humble learning.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit, who is eager to teach you new things.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹⁰

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I go forward with courage, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, power and control.

- As I go forward with courage, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, esteem and affection.
- As I go forward with courage, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, comfort and peace.
- As I go forward with courage, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, change in my situation.
(Pause for 30 seconds)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us to our real glory and to truth. Reveal the real evidence of who we are as You lead us to the next step in our healing this week. Encourage us to co-labor with You to reorient our own lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹www.livingmindfully.org. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross* by Isaac Watts (1674–1748), www.youtube.com/watch?v=U-hz6L6LAug.

³ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (W. W. Norton & Company, 1991), chapter 3.

⁴ James 1:4.

⁵ Luke 6:40.

⁶ www.quotesigma.com/45-famous-quotes-helen-keller.

⁷ Frost, Robert. *North of Boston: A Servant to Servants*. (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1915), lines 56 and 58. Available online at www.bartleby.com/118/9.html.

⁸ Psalm 23:4–5.

⁹ Tolstoy, Leo. *Letters to Friends on the Personal Christian Life*. (Christchurch, Hants: The Free Age Press, 1900), 71, www.azquotes.com/author/14706-Leo_Tolstoy.

¹⁰ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.